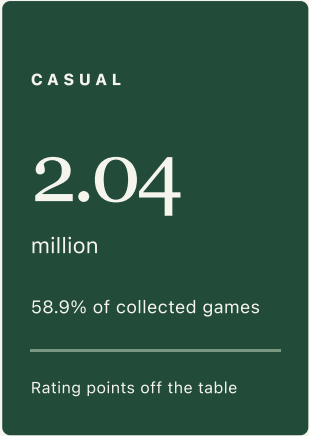


Same Maia. *Two ways to play.*

When rating points are off the table, what changes? A look at shared habits, quick returns and results across **3.47 million** collected games.

Companion to [One more game with Maia](#). Same three bots, same three-year last-move window. All-time profile totals are a separate snapshot.



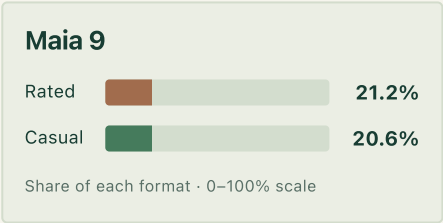
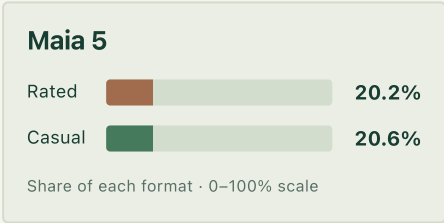
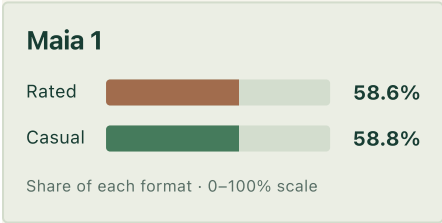
● **One important difference:** 118,056 casual games (5.8%) are tagged fromPosition. All rated games are tagged standard. We separate these when comparing results and repeat play; the bulk metadata has no starting positions. A [follow-up with moves and boards](#) examines the two busiest casual accounts.

01 / WHAT STAYS FAMILIAR

The favorites barely change.

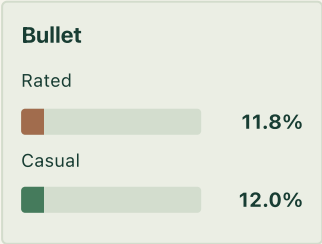
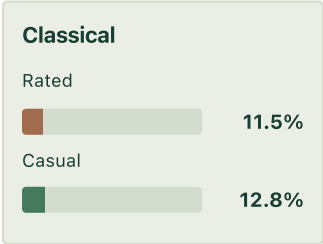
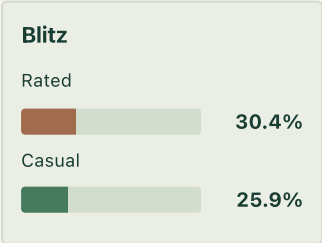
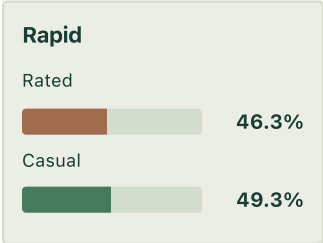
Maia 1 attracts almost the same share in each format: **58.8% casual** and **58.6% rated**. And 10+0 is the most popular exact clock in both.

Rated Casual



A little more slow chess in casual.

Rapid and classical together account for 62.0% of casual games, versus 57.8% of rated games. Those are game-weighted shares, so very active accounts matter.



The same top three clocks.

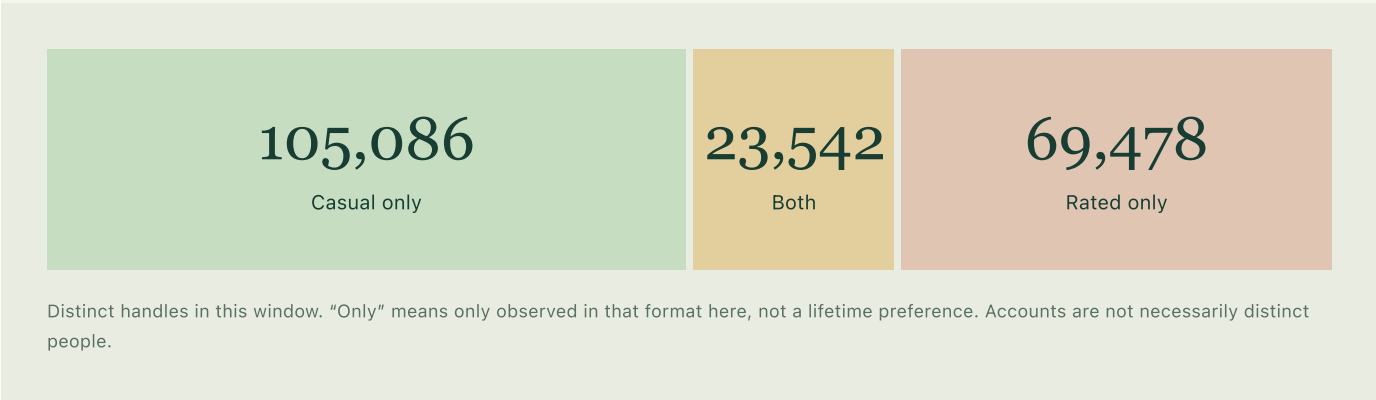
Rank	Rated clock	Rated share	Casual clock	Casual share
1	10+0	15.1%	10+0	16.7%
2	5+3	10.0%	5+3	9.3%
3	10+5	6.1%	10+5	6.8%
4	3+2	4.8%	1+0	6.3%
5	15+10	4.7%	15+10	5.8%

Starting minutes + increment seconds. These preference comparisons include all collected games, including custom-start records. Share denominators are all games in each format.

Watch the 1+0 ranking. One account contributes 63,504 casual 1+0 games in September alone. That is 49.2% of casual 1+0 games in the whole collection. Remove that account's games and 1+0 falls from fourth to seventh; casual bullet's share falls from 12.0% to 9.2%.

A bigger casual audience. A familiar pattern of regulars.

We see 128,628 casual accounts and 93,020 rated accounts. Only **11.9% of the 198,106 distinct observed handles** appear in both formats.



Many visitors. A very active core.

In both formats, roughly four in ten accounts appear just once. Yet just 1% of accounts contribute more than half the games. Casual play has the larger observed audience; neither format is evenly spread across its accounts.

Top 1% is chosen separately for each format, with the number of accounts rounded to the nearest whole account. Anonymous games stay in total-game denominators but cannot enter account counts.

Habit	Rated	Casual
Accounts observed	93,020	128,628
Exactly one observed game	45.2%	41.1%
Median games per account	2	2
Games from busiest 1% of accounts	57.7%	54.0%

Big game counts. Different kinds of activity.

The ten accounts with the most collected casual games against Maia. The top two show unusual repeated patterns, so this is a volume ranking, not a ranking of practice or engagement.

Rank	Account	Casual games	Maia 1	Maia 5	Maia 9
1	<u>scissorsharpness</u>	63,504	57,310	6,193	1
2	<u>top1mostplayedgames</u>	27,506	4,999	12,042	10,465
3	<u>jm_fosho</u>	12,356	692	363	11,301
4	<u>quiron2903</u>	8,758	8,708	45	5
5	<u>djwunited</u>	8,660	8,577	54	29
6	<u>svart7</u>	8,650	2,761	3,697	2,192
7	<u>kftpolaris</u>	7,285	0	0	7,285
8	<u>hutschigutschi</u>	7,262	2	1,813	5,447
9	<u>mabotti</u>	5,738	1,588	3,108	1,042
10	<u>offroadtrip</u>	5,628	1,132	0	4,496

All casual variants included, in the same last-move window: 4 Oct 2023 00:00 UTC to before 4 Oct 2026 09:00 UTC. Ranked by total games, with ties ordered by handle. These are public accounts, not verified individual players. On small screens, scroll the table sideways for the bot breakdown.

scissorsharpness: short games.

All 63,504 games were standard 1+0. 63,343 ended by resignation; the account made a median of 2 moves per game.

top1mostplayedgames: instant mates.

27,504 games ended after one Maia move, before the account moved. Its 27,506 games used just 6 supplied starting positions.

See the [move-level evidence below](#). Counts include these records; no games have been silently removed. [Leaderboard data ↗](#)

A game count is not a practice count.

We recovered moves for all **91,010** collected games from the two busiest casual accounts: **4.46%** of casual volume. Two very different patterns explain those totals.

SCISSORSHARPNESS

99.75%

ended by resignation

A median of **4 half-moves** per game, including 2 by the account. 91.2% ended within six half-moves.

Median gap between starts: **3.71 seconds**. A start gap is not game duration.

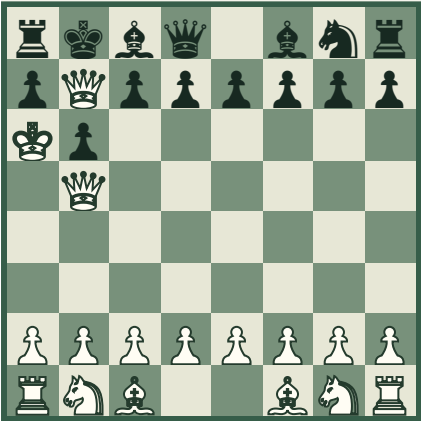
TOP1MOSTPLAYEDGAMES

27,504

mates before the account moved

Almost all 27,506 games ended after **one Maia move**, across just 6 starting boards. Maia won every game.

Median gap between starts: **2.09 seconds**. This is not evidence of normal chess practice.



Even the starting board tells a story.

This setup was used **10,052 times**. White has **17 pieces, including eight pawns**; it fails a basic standard-chess validity check.

All 27,505 mate-tagged games replay to checkmate on their supplied boards. That verifies the endings, not the validity of every starting position.

[Full case study, six boards and daily activity ↗](#)
[Replay results ↗](#) · [Case data ↗](#)

Most repeated supplied board. Black Maia plays **Bxb7#**: bishop takes b7, checkmate.

Maia wins / all standard casual games	All accounts	Exclude examined accounts
Maia 1	67.7%	66.1%
Maia 5	62.6%	62.0%
Maia 9	63.3%	63.3%

The exclusion removes scissorsharpness; top1mostplayedgames is already outside the standard-only subset. Full counts remain available in the [results comparison](#).

Unusual patterns are established; a rules violation is not. Both public profile snapshots reported disabled: true on 8 October 2026, without a reason. These records do not establish who controlled the accounts, how games were initiated, or why the profiles were disabled. [Lichess Fair Play](#) distinguishes prohibited programmatic GUI moves from permitted API methods; these exports do not identify the method used.

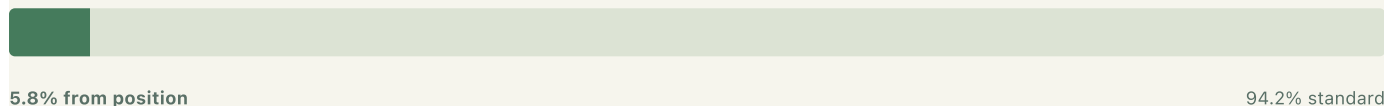
From position doesn't always mean practice.

5.8%

of casual games are tagged
from position.

118,056 games began with the `fromPosition` tag, versus 1,922,672 tagged standard. That is roughly one casual game in seventeen.

The same records are **3.4% of all casual and rated games combined**. None of the collected rated games have this tag.



The new evidence changes the interpretation. `top1mostplayedgames` supplies 23.3% of these games, almost all ending before it makes a move. Excluding that account leaves **90,550 from-position games out of 2,013,222 casual games (4.5%)**. We have not inspected their starting boards.

What could focused practice look like?

Choosing a position could still support the uses below. These are **practice ideas, not explanations established by this dataset**:

01

Rehearse an opening

Start at a familiar branching point and play out the plans that follow, without repeating the first few moves every time.

02

Replay a turning point

Return to a middlegame position from an earlier game, try a different idea, and see how the continuation feels.

03

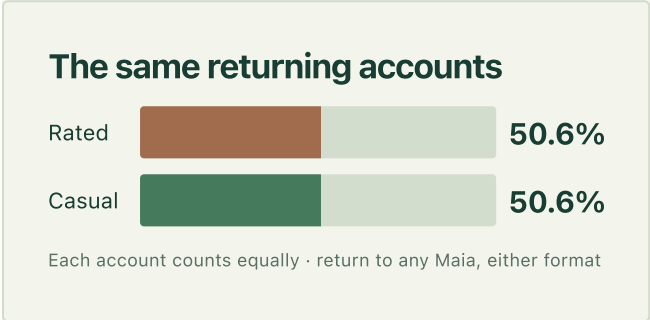
Finish the endgame

Set up a rook ending or a winning position, then practice converting the advantage or holding a difficult defense.

The follow-up recovered moves and starting boards only for the two examined accounts. The remaining bulk records cannot tell us which games were openings, middlegames or endings, or whether anyone improved. The [Lichess board editor](#) illustrates how a supplied position can be used.

Same regulars. Almost identical return rates.

Both formats have a **50.6% quick-return rate** when each qualifying account counts equally. We follow the next observed Maia game across **both** formats. To reduce the effect of different audiences, this comparison uses 2,982 accounts with at least ten eligible standard-start games in each format.



A quick return starts within ten minutes of the previous last recorded move. Each eligible prior game stays in the denominator, even if no later game is observed.

What follows a win or a loss?

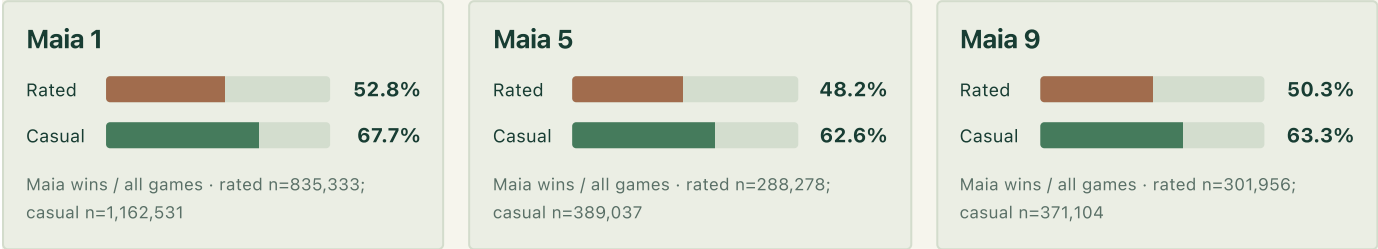
Previous game	Rated	Casual
Any outcome	50.6%	50.6%
Opponent won	39.3%	38.6%
Opponent lost	57.4%	56.2%

Opponent's result in the prior game. For each row, average each qualifying account's return rate equally; outcome-specific rows include only accounts with that outcome. This describes return behavior, not motivation.

Most quick returns stay in the same format. Across eligible standard-start games, 99.2% of quick returns after rated games are rated again; 99.1% after casual games are casual again. This uses all identified accounts, so it is a different population from the equal-account comparison above.

Separate the starting position. Then compare the opponents.

Raw casual and rated results mix different accounts, clocks and starting positions. Below, **standard-tagged games** are the default. Win percentages use **all games**, including draws and unknown outcomes, so they match the definition in the original report.



Both grew. Rated grew faster.

+79.4%

rated games

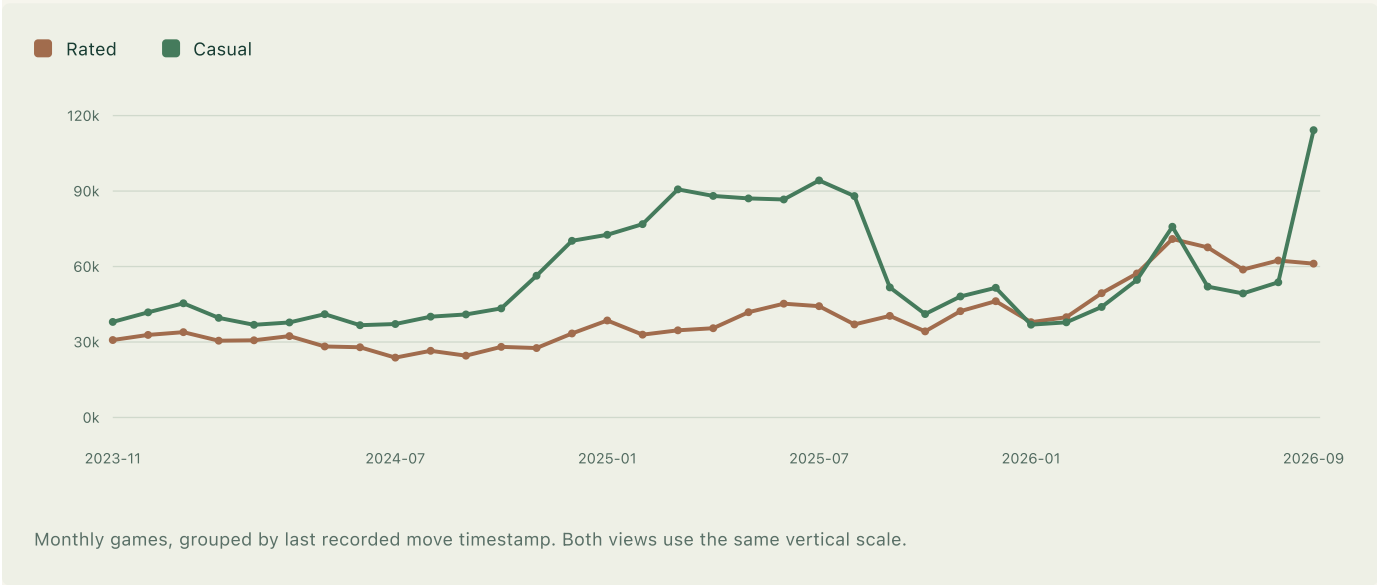
+37.7%

casual games

+24.4%

casual, excluding one account's September games

Earliest complete 12 months: Nov 2023–Oct 2024. Latest: Oct 2025–Sep 2026. This is not a comparison of consecutive years. Partial October 2023 and October 2026 are excluded. Across these blocks, casual's share of combined games falls from 57.8% to 51.2%.



One account, 63,504 September games. That is 55.6% of the month's casual volume. Excluding only those games leaves 50,729 casual September games, versus 53,754 in August. Meanwhile, casual active accounts went from 4,594 in August to 4,446 in September. The volume spike is not a surge in account numbers.

The sensitivity view retains that account's other months and all other games, including top1mostplayedgames. This is a one-account check, not an estimate with every unusual pattern removed. It is a concentration check, not a claim about its identity, motives or legitimacy. We have not verified that every opposing account is human.

Shared habits. Different contexts.

Similarities

The same most-played Maia, the same top three clocks, many one-game visitors and a small core producing most of the games. Those patterns recur in both formats.

Differences

A larger casual audience, limited observed overlap, somewhat more slow chess, and different results—even within a selected matched group. The raw format averages alone do not explain why.

What remains unanswered

Whether one format improves chess skill more. The bulk metadata contains no moves or evaluations. The targeted move-level case study is not a learning study, and the choice of format is not randomized. The original rated early/late analysis remains a separate question.

Check	Rated	Casual
Records	1,425,567	2,040,728
Standard variant tag	1,425,567	1,922,672
fromPosition variant tag	0	118,056
Missing account handles	147	2

Frozen observed exports: last recorded move at or after 4 Oct 2023 00:00 UTC and before 4 Oct 2026 09:00 UTC. All 3,466,295 IDs are unique across the published corpora. Verification covers hashes, sizes, rows, IDs and timestamps; public files cannot independently prove API completeness. Casual collection used a seven-day creation-time lookback; longer boundary-crossing games can still be missed. Recorded Lichess ratings mix speed-specific pools and are not a clean casual skill measure.

[Detailed account case study ↗](#)[Behavior & matched results · JSON ↗](#)[Comparison aggregates · JSON ↗](#)

[Monthly data · CSV ↗](#)[Casual records & field guide ↗](#)[Methods ↗](#)

Source: [Lichess user-game export](#). The bulk CSVs omit moves and starting boards; the separate account-case files include public moves, FENs and available clocks for 91,010 games. No chat, credentials or private identity mappings are included. Independent fan research, not an official Maia or Lichess publication. The MIT license covers original writing and code, not a relicensing of Lichess or player data.